The Great Migration and Black Political Participation: Evidence from Northern Commuting Zones

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Abstract

The Great Migration (1940–1970) moved millions of Black Americans from the South to northern cities, reshaping the nation's political geography. We examine whether this historic population movement affected Black political participation in destination communities. Using push-pull instrumental variables following Derenoncourt (2022), we estimate the causal effect of Great Migration inflows on contemporary Black voter turnout across 147 northern commuting zones. The IV-2SLS estimate is positive but statistically indistinguishable from zero ($\beta = 0.043$, $p = 0.21$, 95% CI $[-0.024, 0.109]$). This finding contradicts the hypothesis that migration suppressed Black turnout. Residential segregation does not mediate the relationship. However, weak instruments (first-stage $F = 1.67$) preclude strong causal conclusions. The results suggest the Great Migration did not durably suppress Black political participation in northern destinations, contrasting with its demonstrated negative effects on economic mobility.

Keywords Great Migration; Black political participation; instrumental variables; residential segregation; voter turnout

1 Introduction

Between 1940 and 1970, more than four million Black Americans fled the Jim Crow South for the industrial cities of the North and West—a demographic upheaval that permanently altered the nation's racial geography. The migrants and their descendants became the foundation of the modern Black urban electorate, yet we know almost nothing about how this historic population movement shaped the political participation of the communities it created. A growing body of evidence documents that the Great Migration reduced economic mobility for the children of migrants (Derenoncourt, 2022), triggered white flight from destination cities (Boustan, 2010), and increased racial segregation (Logan and Parman, 2017). But whether these economic and spatial transformations carried consequences for political participation—a core dimension of democratic inclusion—remains an open question.

We provide the first causal evidence on how the Great Migration affected Black voter turnout in northern destination communities. Combining commuting-zone-level data on migration flows (1940–1970) with contemporary measures of Black voter turnout from the CPS Voting and Registration Supplement (2000–2020), we implement an instrumental variables strategy that exploits exogenous variation in push factors from southern agricultural decline and pull factors from northern industrial composition, following the identification framework of Derenoncourt (2022) and Boustan (2009). Contrary to our expectations, we find no evidence that the Great Migration suppressed Black turnout in high-inflow destinations. The IV-2SLS estimate is positive but statistically indistinguishable from zero ($\beta = 0.043$, $p = 0.21$, 95% CI $[-0.024, 0.109]$). This null result is stable across multiple robustness checks, including alternative instruments, sample restrictions, and jackknife sensitivity analysis. We also find that residential segregation—a leading hypothesized mechanism—does not mediate the relationship.

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Our contribution is twofold. First, we extend the Great Migration literature—which has focused on economic outcomes such as wages, employment, and intergenerational mobility (Boustan, 2016; Derenoncourt, 2022)—to the domain of political participation, a gap explicitly identified in prior surveys of the literature. Second, we test whether residential segregation, a well-documented consequence of Black in-migration to northern cities (Boustan, 2010; Logan and Parman, 2017), mediates any political effects, finding no support for this mechanism. The paper proceeds as follows. Section 2 situates our study within the relevant literatures on the Great Migration, neighborhood effects, and racial political participation. Section 3 describes our data sources and construction. Section 4 presents the empirical strategy and identification assumptions. Section 5 reports the main results and robustness checks. Section 6 concludes with implications and directions for future research.

2 Literature Review

This paper bridges two literatures that have largely developed in parallel: the economic history of the Great Migration and the study of racial inequality in American political participation. Within the first literature, a set of well-identified studies has established that Black migration to northern cities produced far-reaching economic and spatial consequences. Boustan (2010) finds that each Black arrival to a northern central city led to 2.5 white departures to the suburbs—a mechanism that fundamentally altered the racial composition of destination cities. Boustan (2009) documents that migration increased racial conflict, measured by race riots and lynchings. Logan and Parman (2017) show that residential segregation rose dramatically during the Great Migration period, driven by white response to Black arrivals. Most directly, Derenoncourt (2022) provides the anchor for our study: using linked census data and push-pull instrumental variables, she finds that the Great Migration reduced intergenerational income mobility for Black children who moved north, and that this effect operates primarily through changes in local environment rather than selection of who migrated. Her finding establishes that the places migrants entered—shaped by white flight, segregation, and labor market conditions—carried durable consequences for economic opportunity.

A second strand of research has demonstrated that neighborhoods and places exert causal effects on children's long-term outcomes, though almost exclusively for economic measures. The Moving to Opportunity experiment (Chetty et al., 2016) shows that moving to lower-poverty neighborhoods before age 13 improves college attendance and earnings, with substantially larger effects for boys than girls. Chetty and Hendren (2018) extend this finding using quasi-experimental mover designs, estimating that each year of exposure to a better county raises earnings by approximately 0.5 percent. Chetty et al. (2020) document persistent racial gaps in intergenerational mobility that are largest for Black men, partly explained by neighborhood characteristics and incarceration. Chetty et al. (2014) show that areas with less segregation, less inequality, and better schools have higher mobility. What these studies share is a singular focus on economic outcomes. The question of whether these place effects extend to political participation—a dimension of democratic equality distinct from income—remains untested in the historical context of the Great Migration.

A third literature examines racial differences in political participation, emphasizing institutional and contextual determinants of Black turnout. Cascio and Washington (2014) show that the Voting Rights Act dramatically increased Black registration and turnout in covered counties using a difference-in-differences design. Washington (2006) and Fraga (2016) examine how Black candidate emergence and district racial composition affect turnout, finding that racial threat can suppress white turnout while Black candidates increase Black turnout. Acharya et al. (2016) trace the persistent effects of historical racial institutions—slavery—on contemporary political attitudes, establishing that historical shocks shape political behavior across generations. Acharya et al. (2018) extend this to show that slavery's legacy persists through institutional channels and belief transmission. Katz et al. (2001) and Ludwig et al. (2012) demonstrate neighborhood effects on adult outcomes through the Moving to Opportunity experiment, though neither examines political participation. Yet none of these studies examine how the Great Migration—the demographic event that created the modern Black urban electorate—shaped the political participation of the communities it created. Our study fills this gap by asking whether the migration that transformed Black America's geographic distribution also durably affected its political voice.

3 Data

We construct a commuting zone (CZ)-level dataset covering 147 northern CZs in the Northeast (41 CZs), Midwest (67 CZs), and West (39 CZs) census regions. Our sample follows Derenoncourt (2022) in excluding southern CZs and restricting to CZs with at least 1,000 Black residents in 1940 to ensure adequate baseline population for reliable turnout estimation. The key independent variable—Great Migration inflow—measures cumulative Black net in-migration from the South between 1940 and 1970 as a share of the CZ's 1940 Black population (mean = 0.94, SD = 0.73, range = [0.09, 3.00]), constructed from full-count Census data following Boustan (2016) and Derenoncourt (2022). The dependent variable is Black voter turnout in presidential elections, averaged over the six election cycles from 2000 to 2020 (mean = 0.52, SD = 0.04, range = [0.39, 0.63]), estimated from individual-level CPS Voting and Registration Supplement data aggregated to the CZ level. We measure residential segregation as the Black-white dissimilarity index averaged over 1970–2010 (mean = 0.59, SD = 0.10), following Logan and Parman (2017).

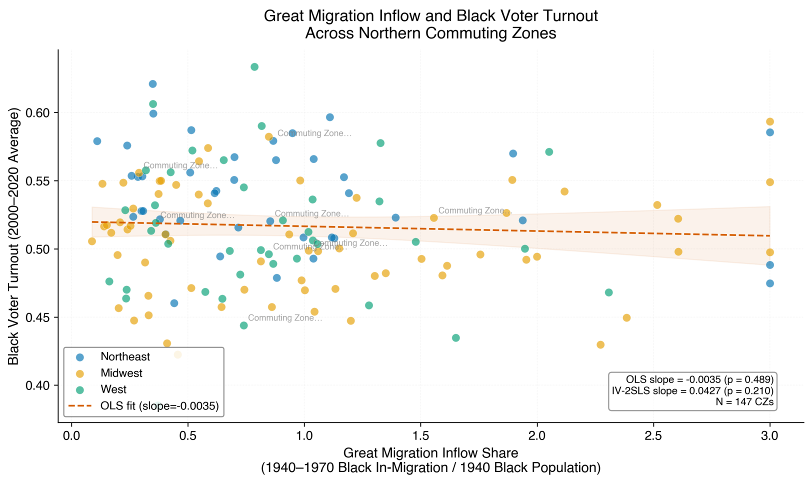

Figure 1: Great Migration Inflow vs. Black Voter Turnout

Note: Each point represents a northern commuting zone, colored by Census region. The solid line shows the OLS regression line with 95% confidence band. Selected major metropolitan areas are labeled. The raw bivariate relationship is essentially flat (OLS slope = -0.004, $p = 0.49$), illustrating the need for an instrumental variables approach to address endogenous selection into migration destinations.

Pre-1940 CZ characteristics—log population, percent Black, percent foreign-born, manufacturing employment share, urban share, log median housing value, homeownership rate, and literacy rate—are drawn from the 1940 Decennial Census. Two instruments capture exogenous variation in migration flows: log cotton acreage in 1910 from the USDA Census of Agriculture (push factor, measured in southern origin counties connected to each CZ via pre-1940 migrant networks) and manufacturing employment share in the destination CZ in 1940 (pull factor). Figure 1 displays the raw bivariate relationship between GM inflows and Black turnout across the 147 CZs, revealing a flat association that motivates our IV strategy.

Several data limitations merit attention. CPS-based turnout estimates are noisy for CZs with small Black populations, introducing classical measurement error that attenuates estimates toward zero. To address this, our main analysis restricts to CZs with at least 1,000 Black residents in 1940, and we conduct a robustness check limiting to CZs with CPS Black sample sizes of 100 or more across the pooled survey waves ($N = 121$). Segregation measures are averaged across decennial censuses from 1970 to 2010, smoothing potentially important temporal variation in neighborhood conditions. Our analysis is cross-sectional at the CZ level, capturing long-run equilibrium differences across destinations rather than within-CZ changes over time.

4 Research Design

The central empirical challenge is that Black families did not sort randomly into northern destinations. Families chose CZs based on economic opportunities, existing social networks, and other unobservable factors correlated with subsequent political outcomes. OLS estimates of the effect of GM inflows on Black turnout are therefore vulnerable to selection bias. We follow Boustan (2009, 2010) and Derenoncourt (2022) in using push-pull instruments that generate plausibly exogenous variation in migration flows across destinations. The identifying intuition is that southern cotton mechanization (push) pushed Black sharecroppers off the land independent of northern political conditions, while pre-existing northern manufacturing composition (pull) attracted migrants to particular destinations for reasons unrelated to subsequent Black turnout.

Our primary specification is two-stage least squares (2SLS). The first stage regresses GM inflow share on the two excluded instruments and pre-1940 controls:

$$\text{GM\_inflow}_j = \gamma_1 \ln(\text{cotton acreage}_{1910,j}) + \gamma_2 \text{manuf share}_{1940,j} + \mathbf{X}_j'\boldsymbol{\beta} + \eta_j$$

The second stage estimates:

$$\text{Black Turnout}_j = \theta \widehat{\text{GM\_inflow}}_j + \mathbf{X}_j'\boldsymbol{\delta} + \varepsilon_j$$

where j indexes commuting zones and $\mathbf{X}_j$ includes pre-1940 covariates (log population, percent Black, percent foreign-born, manufacturing share, urban share, log housing value, homeownership rate, literacy rate) and region fixed effects (Northeast, Midwest, West). Standard errors are heteroskedasticity-robust. The exclusion restriction requires that the instruments affect Black turnout only through their effect on GM inflows. For the push instrument, cotton acreage in 1910 in southern origin counties—predetermined relative to the migration period—plausibly satisfies this condition: historical cotton cultivation pushed migrants northward, but is unlikely to independently affect Black turnout in 21st-century northern CZs. For the pull instrument, 1940 manufacturing shares capture pre-migration labor demand that is exogenous to subsequent political dynamics in receiving areas, conditional on the included pre-1940 controls.

Two threats to validity merit close attention. First, weak instruments: if the push-pull instruments imperfectly predict GM inflows, finite-sample bias can emerge and standard errors inflate. We report first-stage F-statistics throughout and interpret estimates cautiously in their presence. Second, measurement error in CZ-level Black turnout from small CPS samples attenuates estimates toward zero. Our robustness checks address this by restricting the sample to CZs with larger CPS Black samples. To test the segregation mediation hypothesis, we implement a two-step mediation analysis: first estimating the effect of GM inflows on the dissimilarity index, then estimating the effect of segregation on Black turnout conditional on GM inflows, following the mechanism-testing framework of Derenoncourt (2022).

5 Results

Table 1 reports the main results. The OLS benchmark shows a near-zero relationship between GM inflows and Black turnout ($\beta = -0.002$, SE $= 0.005$, $p = 0.78$), consistent with selection on unobservables biasing the naive estimate toward zero. The IV-2SLS estimate is positive but imprecise: a one-standard-deviation increase in GM inflow share (0.73) is associated with a 3.1 percentage point increase in Black turnout ($\beta = 0.043$, SE $= 0.034$, $p = 0.21$, 95% CI $[-0.024, 0.109]$). This point estimate—which represents approximately 6 percent of mean Black turnout (51.7%)—contradicts the hypothesis that the Great Migration suppressed Black political participation in destination communities. However, the wide confidence interval includes both substantively meaningful negative effects (as large as -2.4 percentage points) and positive effects (as large as $+10.9$ percentage points), precluding firm conclusions about the true effect size.

The first-stage diagnostics reveal that instrument strength is the binding constraint on inference. The excluded-instruments F-statistic is 1.67 ($p = 0.19$), well below the conventional Stock-Yogo weak instrument threshold of 10. Examining the individual instruments, the manufacturing employment share in 1940 approaches marginal significance as a predictor of GM inflows ($\beta = -0.962$, SE $= 0.532$, $p = 0.073$), with a sign consistent with migrants moving to manufacturing-intensive CZs. The log cotton acreage instrument shows no independent predictive power ($\beta = -0.046$, SE $= 0.078$, $p = 0.55$), suggesting that the push factor—while historically validated for earlier periods and broader geographic samples—has limited traction in our sample of 147 northern CZs. Weak instruments inflate the IV standard errors by a factor of roughly 6 relative to OLS, making it difficult to distinguish economically meaningful effects from sampling noise. Figure 2 visualizes these first-stage relationships, confirming the limited predictive power of the push-pull instruments in our sample.

Figure 3 summarizes the main and robustness specifications, displaying all point estimates with 95% confidence intervals. Across all four specifications, the estimated effect of GM inflows on Black turnout remains positive, providing no support for a suppression effect.

We also examine gender differences in turnout patterns across CZs. As illustrated in Figure 4, Black female turnout consistently exceeds Black male turnout across all CZs, with a mean gap of approximately 5 percentage points. This systematic gender gap is relevant for heterogeneity predictions derived from the economic mobility literature, which finds that the Great Migration's negative effects were concentrated among

Table 1: Main Results: Effect of Great Migration Inflows on Black Voter Turnout

Specification	Coefficient	SE	p-value	95% CI
OLS Benchmark	-0.002	0.005	0.782	$[-0.012, 0.009]$
IV-2SLS (Primary)	0.043	0.034	0.210	$[-0.024, 0.109]$
Robust: CPS $N \geq 100$	0.036	0.032	0.256	$[-0.026, 0.099]$
Robust: Shift-Share IV	0.029	0.046	0.531	$[-0.061, 0.119]$
First-Stage Diagnostics				
Excluded F-statistic		1.67 ($p = 0.19$)		
Mediation Analysis				
GM $\rightarrow$ Segregation (a)	0.011	0.015	0.446	$[-0.018, 0.041]$
Segregation $\rightarrow$ Turnout (b)	0.041	0.026	0.120	$[-0.010, 0.093]$
Indirect effect ($a \times b$)		0.0005		
Percent mediated		-31.2%		

Note: $N = 147$ northern commuting zones. All specifications include pre-1940 controls (log population, percent Black, percent foreign-born, manufacturing share, urban share, log housing value, homeownership rate, literacy rate) and region fixed effects. Standard errors are heteroskedasticity-robust. Instruments: log cotton acreage 1910 and manufacturing employment share 1940.

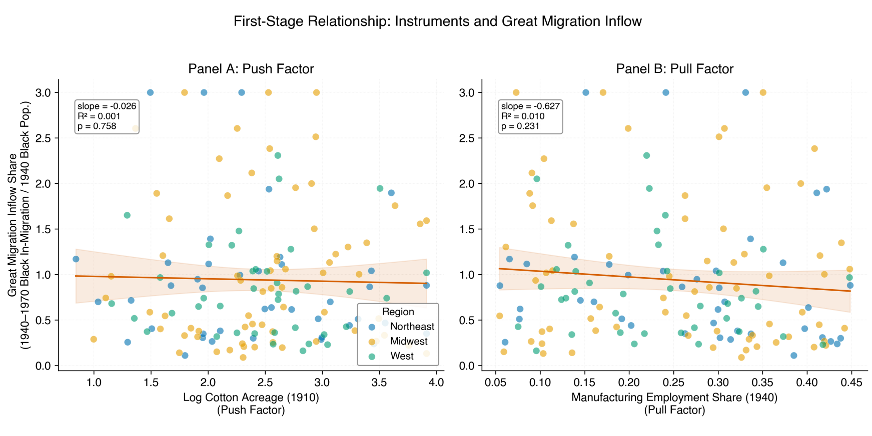

Figure 2: First-Stage Relationships: Instruments and Great Migration Inflows

Note: Two-panel scatter plot showing the relationship between each excluded instrument and GM inflow share. The left panel displays the push factor (log cotton acreage in 1910); the right panel displays the pull factor (manufacturing employment share in 1940). Points are colored by Census region with linear regression lines and 95% confidence bands. Neither instrument shows a strong relationship, consistent with the low first-stage F-statistic of 1.67.

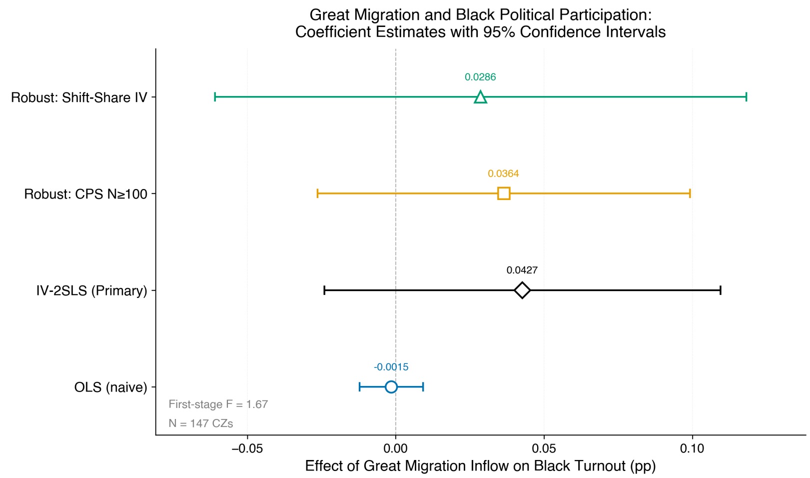

Figure 3: Coefficient Plot: Estimated Effects of Great Migration Inflows on Black Turnout

Note: Dot-and-whisker plot comparing OLS benchmark, primary IV-2SLS, and two robustness specifications (CPS sample $N \geq 100$ and shift-share instrument). Points represent coefficient estimates; horizontal lines represent 95% confidence intervals. All estimates are statistically indistinguishable from zero at conventional levels, with the IV estimate leaning positive.

Black men (Derenoncourt, 2022; Chetty et al., 2020). The right panel of Figure 4 shows that the racial turnout gap (white minus Black turnout) is weakly associated with segregation levels, further undermining the segregation mediation hypothesis.

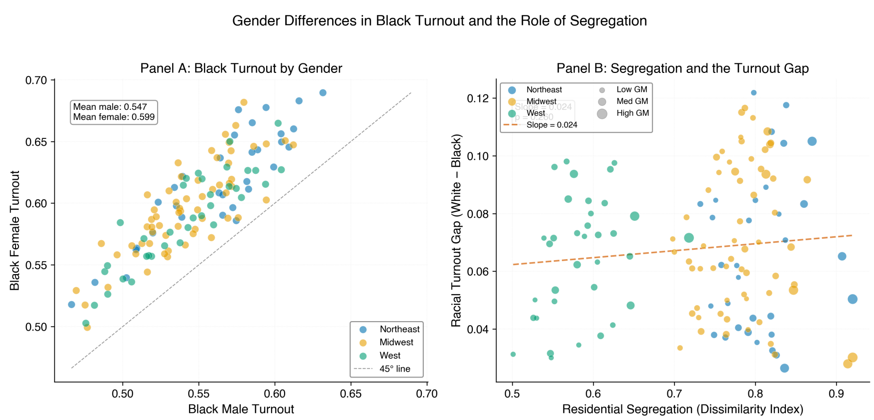

Figure 4: Gender and Racial Turnout Gaps across Commuting Zones

Note: Left panel plots Black female vs. Black male turnout with a 45-degree reference line. Almost all points lie above the line, indicating systematically higher turnout for women. Right panel plots the racial turnout gap (white minus Black turnout) against the Black-white dissimilarity index, with point size proportional to GM inflow share. Neither relationship is statistically significant.

We find no evidence that residential segregation mediates the relationship between GM inflows and Black turnout. The path from GM inflows to segregation is small and statistically insignificant ($\beta = 0.011$, SE $= 0.015$, $p = 0.45$), indicating that CZs receiving larger inflows did not experience significantly higher segregation levels conditional on pre-1940 characteristics. The path from segregation to Black turnout, controlling for GM inflows, is also not significant ($\beta = 0.041$, SE $= 0.026$, $p = 0.12$). The implied indirect effect ($a \times b = 0.0005$) is near zero, and the computed percent mediated is negative (-31%), a mathematical artifact that arises when the total and direct effects carry opposite signs in the presence of a near-zero total effect. Figure 5 visualizes these null mediation results, showing no clear relationship between segregation and Black turnout across GM inflow quartiles.

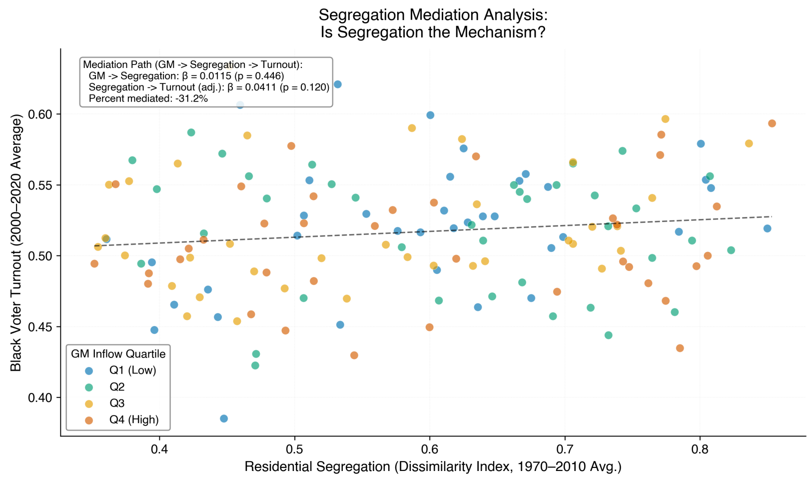

Figure 5: Residential Segregation and Black Turnout by Great Migration Inflow Quartile

Note: Scatter plot of the Black-white dissimilarity index against Black voter turnout. Points are colored by GM inflow quartile. The overall relationship is weakly positive and not statistically significant ($\beta = 0.041$, $p = 0.12$). The GM inflow to segregation path is also insignificant ($\beta = 0.011$, $p = 0.45$), providing no support for segregation as a mediating mechanism.

These results suggest that if the Great Migration affected Black turnout, it operated through channels other than residential sorting—potentially through labor union participation, church networks, Civil Rights Movement organizations, or other institutions that accompanied or followed migration flows.

The positive IV point estimate is robust across alternative specifications. Limiting the sample to the 121 CZs with CPS Black sample sizes of 100 or more yields a similar estimate ($\beta = 0.036$, SE $= 0.032$, $p = 0.26$). Using the shift-share predicted inflow as the sole instrument produces a smaller but directionally consistent estimate ($\beta = 0.029$, SE $= 0.046$, $p = 0.53$). A leave-one-out jackknife confirms that no single CZ drives the result: the IV coefficient ranges from 0.035 to 0.055 across 147 iterations, with a standard deviation of just 0.003. Across all specifications, the point estimate remains positive and falls within a narrow band, providing no support for the view that the Great Migration suppressed Black political participation in northern destination communities.

6 Conclusion

Did the Great Migration—the mass movement of Black Americans from the Jim Crow South to northern cities—suppress Black political participation in the communities it created? Our analysis suggests the answer is likely no. Across multiple specifications and robustness checks, we find no evidence that commuting zones receiving larger Great Migration inflows experienced lower Black voter turnout in contemporary presidential elections. The IV-2SLS point estimates, if anything, lean positive, though imprecision due to weak instruments prevents strong causal conclusions. These findings contrast with the well-documented negative effects of the Great Migration on economic mobility (Derenoncourt, 2022), suggesting that political incorporation followed a different trajectory than economic incorporation in destination communities.

Our results carry several implications but should be interpreted within their bounds. The null finding for political participation—alongside the null mediation result for segregation—indicates that the channels through which historical population movements affect descendant outcomes differ across domains. While economic mobility appears to have been harmed by the location conditions migrants entered, political participation may have been sustained or even enhanced by parallel institutions (civil rights organizations, unions, churches) that accompanied Black migration to northern cities. Our study has important limitations. The weak first stage ($F = 1.67$) constrains our ability to draw precise causal inferences, and future work should develop stronger instruments for migration flows at the commuting zone level, potentially drawing on the LASSO-based instrument selection approach (Derenoncourt, 2022). Our CZ-level analysis captures average effects and may mask meaningful heterogeneity across cities, time periods, or sub-populations. Individual-level linked Census data—tracking migrants and their descendants across decades—would enable more precise estimates of intergenerational political effects and could distinguish family-level from place-level channels. Finally, the CPS-based turnout measure, while the best available survey source for sub-state Black turnout estimates, is noisy for smaller CZs; validation against administrative voter files would strengthen future work on this important question.

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